**Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay**

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

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**Critical Notes on Elizabeth Barrett Browning's "Patience Taught by Nature"**

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the speaker's comparison of how a person handles existing as perceived difficulty to how nature handles simply existing in Elizabeth Barret Browning's "Patience Taught by Nature" include

alliteration,
apostrophe,
assonance,
controlling image,
enjambment,
imagery,
melopoeia,
meter,
octave,
onomatopoeia,
pathetic fallacy,
personification,
rhyme scheme,
sestet,
simile,
sigmatism,
sonnet,
speaker,
theme, and
tone.

The young literary critic should recognize that the speaker's comparison takes in the fullness of the world, animate and inanimate, flora and fauna, here on earth and beyond to include "the unwasted stars" (line 10), which represent "[i]n their old glory" (line 11) time, the temporal as—literally—the companion to patience.

The contestant might choose to focus on the imagery—auditory, visual, tactile—that reinforces the notion that nature is characterized by untroubled beauty and serene (line 4) purposefulness, which the speaker contrasts with human experience/existence that is characterized as both dreary (line 1) and burdened by meeting Heaven's expectations (lines 4-6).

The speaker's asking "the God of old" (line 11) for the grace to be patient, even as little patience as the arguably personified blade of grass needs to get through the vicissitudes—the extremes—of existence (lines 13-14) might be recognized by the close reader as a contrast to "generations of birds / Sing[ing] through our sighing" (lines 2-3): Nature has long not complained, and our weakness, measured against the natural world's strength, needs but a "smaller grace" (line 12) to learn and perhaps to emulate the flocks and the herds, the oceans and the savannah, the trees and the stars.